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Chuck Lamb

Pianist and composer Chuck Lamb has enjoyed a diverse career as a leader of a jazz fusion group, and as an accompanist to numerous jazz soloists. He is currently a member of the Brubeck Brothers Quartet and hosts monthly jazz events at the venerable Caffe Lena in Saratoga, NY.

Chuck was interviewed in Clinton, NY on February 7, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I'm very pleased to have Chuck Lamb today at the — returning to the scene of a concert, you know it was almost a year ago when you played here with the Brubeck Brothers at Hamilton College.

CL: Right.

MR: That was an awesome concert. So before the quote tape was rolling, you were playing a little introduction so could I request an interview introduction?

CL: Sure. And you know I was just telling you that when I do these tours with the Brubecks and get into the hall and it's usually pretty quiet and they have these beautiful grand pianos and I turn on my recorder because every piano has some sort of voice and this has a ton of music in it so I'll just see what pops out right now.

[musical interlude]

MR: Oh yeah. I'm going to dub in some applause because it's worth it. You know I know classical people who would really envy that ability and I'm going to stay here for a moment and first of all you said there's a lot of music in this piano. What does that actually mean for you?

CL: The sound of the instrument, you know like when I got here like I explained before with the Brubeck thing, I did that with this piano and four or five different themes came out immediately. You know? Just letting my hands fall and start to improvise off of the reaction I get from the instrument. And you know that's developed over a long period of time to have the trust to be able to do that, just to sit down and let my hands fall.

[musical interlude]

So these themes, just, they come out and they start singing to me and I just let my hands follow it, you know. It's pretty, you know, obviously superfast how that happens and you react instantly to it but it's one of my biggest joys is to let that stuff emerge as it will. It's really —

MR: I've always thought it's improvising, especially this type of thing that you're doing, can only be explained so far. There's a magic to it that, at least I can't put it into words and

I'm not sure if there was a specific answer to how it's done that I'd even want to know because it takes some of the — it's magic I guess, is what I'm trying to say.

CL: It's some kind of magic in one sense, and then in another it's like — I guess it's like poetry or, you know, having mastered enough of the theoretical knowledge — for me — of you know theory and harmony and playing music, classical music you know, and I'm very influenced by Debussy and Ravel, their beautiful compositions which are very improvised also. You know what's the Stravinsky quote, that composition is selective improvisation. And that, you know, that's just the way it is. You sit down, you know as it evolves, but you sit down and you improvise and you go oh my God, I love that theme. And then you start to develop a theme but it's based off of some sort of improv.

MR: Theoretical knowledge you mentioned — I'm curious because we go back a long ways and you come from a small town called Verona, New York, and I remember wondering back then seeing you in this band called Dry Jack, where did you and your brother, how did you come to this music, which at the time we would have — we'll call it jazz fusion I guess.

CL: Oh the fusion thing. You know man it was like playing — I started playing drums, you know that was my first axe. And then — when I was ten — and that was pretty much, that was it for me as far as the devotion to music. But Rich and I were in bands up until — like for fifteen years straight and we developed musically as we went along and started getting into — you know the fusion thing probably started with stuff we were doing cover tunes like Jeff Beck and we were doing, and then I was in a band called the Breakthrough with Rich and Gary Colmey and these Verona guys. And we did tunes by Yes, you know, and Yes was like, if you think about it, you know [scats]. Right? I mean that was like, I was really attracted to unison lines: bass player, guitar, bass, keyboard. I love that. And then that turned into hearing Chick Corea and his and the Seventh Galaxy. You know [scats] all that classic fusion stuff. And then we heard Return to Forever at here — at the chapel —

MR: At Hamilton.

CL: At Hamilton. That was like 1973 and that did the trick 'cause there was a, you know these guys were brilliant. Stanley Clarke, Chick, Lenny White, Bill Connors was on guitar. And it was a spiritual experience. These guys were plugged in to the source. And I remember that chapel just like — and I was oh my God man, music can do that, you know lift you up. And it was a lot of improvisation. I remember there was a piano, a grand piano off the stage on the floor and Chick went down to start the second set, he climbed off the stage and went over and he did that. He improvised this thing and it was like, that's the keys to the castle right there man.

MR: I saw them about the same time.

CL: Did you?

MR: And it was at Syracuse University. And I was in a band later that played Yes and all that stuff. But when I saw that group, with Bill Connors, it was the same thing. Like awestruck.

CL: Yeah. It was awestruck you know. And we walked out of that, I remember Rich and I were like um hum, okay. And I don't know why man, I was composing pretty quickly when I started playing piano, which I was about fifteen. And as soon as that happened the composition thing really took off.

MR: Did you laboriously write this music you were writing down with pen and paper?

CL: Not much.

MR: I wondered about that because we'll talk about your, the Dry Jack LPs in a moment, but when I heard those tunes and I envisioned writing all those melodies which were pretty complex, and then the other guys learning them.

CL: Right.

MR: Was it mostly by ear?

CL: Yeah it was mostly by ear. I mean I did write the stuff down you know, and made a, it was an effort for me because I learned to play by ear and you know, going back to really crack the code of exactly what I'm writing, you know, in sixteenth notes and — I really had to study that. But not that we used the charts, but I wanted to have it documented somehow and I still have those charts, it's really funny to look at, you know, the scrawl. But yeah, we just — Rod Fleeman, the guitar player from Dry Jack, I just talked to him three or four days ago and he's going, "Man you never wrote any of that stuff down." You know? He brought that up which I had forgotten that it really was about that, about the showing him.

MR: Did your parents support your endeavors or did they think — was there ever any talk about getting a real job?

CL: No.

MR: That's good.

CL: My mom especially was like, when there was talk about me going maybe to music school, actually more it was a reflection back on the time she was like, we talked, "Mom did you ever think of sending Chuck to music school?" And she said, "No, musician, musician. He has to go out and play." I never —

MR: That's a very enlightened attitude I think.

CL: Yeah. And my parents were both, well my mom was a singer and she was like in an Andrews Sisters trio with her two sisters in New York City, so that element, and my dad was a very creative artist. But you know they heard, when I was eight or nine, playing, I just had some drum sticks and playing on lampshades and that stuff. Maybe it was to save

the lampshades but they bought me a drum set when I was ten, for a birthday present, from Montgomery Wards, red sparkle Kent. Yes baby. One bass drum, a pole in the middle, one cymbal you know up here. Oh I was in heaven. And then Rich and I started our first band called The Plastic People.

MR: Was he always a bassist?

CL: No he played guitar, he played guitar kind of throughout that thing and then when we made the switch, there's a lot of ancillary roots in these stories of course, but my brother, the next oldest brother, John, was a guitar player and he was playing with us also so there was three brothers. He went to Columbia University and met a drummer, a really great jazz drummer who came back to Verona and then it was like well how about he plays drums and you play piano? It was sort of the start of my — and I said okay. That was just what we did. And we went, "Rich, play bass." So it was all organically evolving.

MR: Did you have a clear idea, a goal, a concept of what it meant to make it in the music business?

CL: No. No we didn't even — we were just so into playing and you know getting gigs and playing out and developing the music. We didn't think about that stuff. We knew that something was happening with the band that, wow we could, this could do something. So yeah I mean that's sort of part of what you're asking. But you know like the evolution of all of that was so organic you know. "Hey let's make a cassette tape and send it to Inner City Records," which is where we got the record. You know it was a cassette.

MR: And you actually got a response?

CL: They loved it. They said, "This is great, we'd like to explore this further. Can you do another recording" which we tried to do at this club in Kansas City. We sent that to him and he said, "Yeah this sounds good but it's not quite the sound that we need for a recording." I think there were some buzzes or whatever. And then about six months passed and then we got a call from them and they said, "We'd like you guys to come to New York City and record some records."

MR: Did you jump up and down at the time?

CL: Oh man, you know it's funny man we were in Kansas City gigging and had all the original material I had been writing, all of that had jelled. And so we were a force, we were so content and so happy to be putting this out. And I remember we got the record deal and we went to see Pat Metheny who we were friends with, and he just got his record deal with ECM with Lyle Mays and that band. So we thought oh man, this is cool you know.

MR: Would you mind holding up, I think those LPs are right there.

CL: Oh yeah. So this was the first Dry Jack thing, "Magical Elements" and then "Whale City."

MR: Well I wore them out.

CL: Look at these youngsters.

MR: And I was envious because everybody that had a band — unless you were strictly a part timer — was sort of trying to get to that level. Oh my God an LP, we got a record deal.

CL: Yeah, right.

MR: You got a record. Did it proceed from there as you hoped or what was it like dealing with a small record label?

CL: Oh it was incredible. Maybe because of the small label thing but you know they just, there was no restrictions musically on what we were doing and there was a lot of freedom in the studio time-wise — just go ahead and make this record. But you know we had been playing — the only way we could make a record was to play live in the studio, which was trickier back then, the technology to do live and not have bleed with instruments and this kind of thing. But we basically played live in the studio and then I did my overdubs on my clavinet and my mini Moog and stuff. Right? Man, you know, it was great. And that band was — the guitar player, for personal reasons, left and moved back to Kansas City. So that ended — which was a drag because we were on a roll and we had just recorded a third album demo for Inner City which was called "Alien Intervention," all this kind of wild stuff I had been composing. It was a really neat record. So then he left and then trying to create, you can't re-create that vibe of what we had, no matter if you get the same instruments it doesn't matter. So I just took that as a cue to start moving a little in a bit of a different direction. But I got Mike Demicco, who is the guitar player with me in the Brubeck Quartet and so I got him out of his gig at a hotel or something. So he was very grateful to be playing all of this great music. And then fast forward twenty years later he's the one that said to Chris Brubeck, "Hey you've got to get Chuck Lamb."

MR: All right.

CL: Kind of a returned favor. That's pretty neat.

MR: That's neat. That's a fraternity of musicians. And I think it behooves people to know that to act professional in whatever thing you are doing because as you say, twenty years down the line some someone's going to think —

CL: Yes. That's a great point. And you know if you're playing in a jazz club and you're cool with the staff, you know you go out of your way, "Hey man, thanks for taking care of us." You know that dude could start running a jazz club. And that's happened to me before, where the waiter opened up this jazz club in Aspen. He said, "Hey man can you come?" "Bill? Really, is that you?" So just what you're saying. You know be aware of your environment, who you're working for and just make sure you're present. Because you don't know.

MR: What was the other, after Dry Jack the — I have to insert one thing because this stuck in my head, for our viewers, I was teaching at the school they you had sort of recently graduated from, at Vernon, Verona, Sherrill and you guys were together pre Inner City and you asked me to come over to this house where you were all living I think cause you wanted to learn some, I don't know what it was, theory.

CL: Rich. My brother Rich. I told you he said to say hi and he said, "Oh man, Monk, that's great." But he said, "Do you remember he came over to the house to teach us" Rich said he came over to teach us theory. And I remember you coming over and hanging. I just remember you were a really cool guy and we had a lot of fun. But you know Rich said, "Yeah" though, our history man is pretty cool.

MR: I said, "Play a tune for me you guys."

CL: Oh you did okay.

MR: And when it was over I said, "What the hell do you want me to show you?" It was great. Because when I got out of college I had this bit of an attitude that people who didn't also go to college and study music were somewhat lesser musicians. And then I learned along the way that people who learned by ear had a whole other thing that I didn't have and that it's very valuable. And sometimes in composing they think of things to do chord-wise or whatever-wise, that schooled musicians wouldn't think of, or would think of and dismiss.

CL: You know that was part of the discussion about, you know with my peers about not going to school. They're going, "Man who knows what that would have done to your creative spirit" which you know just what you're saying. I understand that that might have dampened it, to get too theoretical and too into the learning thing, and take away from the improv-ability but then again I don't think I would have been deterred by anything you know, I would have just enjoyed the knowledge coming at me. And I remember our guitar player at that time, because Rich told me that, I can't say I remember, Rich said that the guitar player in the band when you came over, he was like, "I don't want to learn anything. I just want to keep doing this. Why are we trying to learn stuff?" That was so great of you to come over man. And, you know, because you were a well-respected player by us too so it was like wow man, this guy is like a serious musician. And you still are man, still a great player.

MR: Has — this is sort of an obvious question but paying your rent as a musician, making a living, has there been ups and downs for you?

CL: Sure. But never to the point of, you know, red alert. Never to that point. It always worked out. You know like after Rod left and I started the new Dry Jack thing, you know there was some financial struggles but like for instance right after that band broke up I moved into an apartment down near Woodstock and my landlord was Dave Holland.

MR: Oh my.

CL: Right? One of the greatest, to me, the greatest bass player on the planet and one of the greatest composers. So he was my landlord and I would go over and play with him all the time. He'd call me up and say, "I just got these charts from Kenny Wheeler, do you want to be come over and read through these charts?" Or, you know, and the big one was he had heart surgery — he had a valve replaced, and this was back in, man, '82, so it was a little bit newer of a — it wasn't quite so — the technology was very different. So his recovery time was long and he called me up and he said, "Would you be willing to come over two or three times a week for the next couple of months and help me get back in shape?" And that changed my whole thinking on my approach to improvisation. I mean this guy was such a master that I learned so much about relaxation, you know, expression to follow your — all of these subliminal kind of things that just altered my course improvisation-wise, composition-wise, and so that was a huge time in my life. And you know it was a struggling time financially but it didn't really matter, other stuff was happening that was more powerful. But by the end of like two and a half months into it as he was getting stronger and stronger I started, I was like holy — I mean the elevation of his playing and the power of it and the, you know the lift. I was now rather than overjoyed by playing with him, blown completely away at this master you know, hanging out in his practice room playing with me. So that was —

MR: Can you imagine what you would have had to pay a teacher to get that kind of stuff, and you still wouldn't have got it anyway probably. The situation was just sort of perfect for you.

CL: Right. So that was a big deal. And then I moved to the Rocky Mountains, to Colorado in the late 80s and right away got a gig at a club in Vail called Louie's, which was this jazz club that wanted to happen. And then I was picked as the piano player six nights a week, play with a trio and bring acts in that are traveling, you know Nick Brignola, Ernie Watts, do you remember?

MR: Oh gee. Yeah.

CL: Right?

MR: He's on my list to ask you about.

CL: Oh yeah, so all these cats traveling through, plus local guys: Ron Miles who is a beautiful trumpet player. So I booked this thing for eight and a half years, you know, six nights a week I would play. And I'd do the ski season and then I'd do the summer. I mean it was crazy. So that was that period of time, and then right when that ended I got offered to do a solo piano jazz gig at this club in Vail also. And I did that for nine years. So financially things were cool.

MR: Were these fellas, when they came in to sit in with your trio or be booked with your trio, did they bring charts?

CL: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: That's somewhat helpful.

CL: You know even back then, and I do that at my current gig at Caffe Lena, I want your music and I want to get your music before, you know like Louie's was usually a couple of days before but I want to get your music so — I'm not a great sight reader, I'm working on it but I want to be able to know your music well enough when we're presenting a concert for it to sound like that. Plus I learn, man, how much you learn doing that. You get into somebody else's head, somebody else's trip, somebody else's compositional technique that to this day with the gig I'm doing, it's like man —

MR: Well you went to college after all.

CL: Yeah right. That's funny. [inaudible]

MR: Are there wrong notes in improvising?

CL: No. Because you — I mean so if I'm improvising on something and there's not a lot of thought going on you're just really following the flow of what's happening and then if I'll go up to what would be a wrong note I would just change what I'm doing for it to match. Like if it's a half step above — not to get, you know — but you just navigate what that note is, you navigate if another player does something funky like that, go ahead and grab it and make it a like oh my God that was brilliant you know. You could reharmonize it to — and you know you're working like that and if you're working with players on that level it's like that's the coolest stuff on a gig when that happens.

MR: I heard you do that last night, believe it or not. I was watching the video from Small's where you were playing with Diego. How do you pronounce his last name?

CL: Diego Figueiredo.

MR: And you were playing [scats].

CL: Playing "Wave" yeah.

MR: And that was happening I think, and he would do something and almost instantaneously you played in a fashion that enhanced or went with it. And vice versa when you started playing.

CL: Yeah he's a cat that — that connection is very deep like that. It was from the first time we played, we both recognized that, I mean culturally very different upbringings but the improv thing, the freedom improv thing just jelled with us.

MR: There was a part in the middle of it where I suggest people get on the Internet and try to find it, where it was like you turned into J.S. Bach for a little while. It was sort of a contrapuntal two thing. But going back to the wrong note business, and I wish I could think of a better term than wrong — unintended perhaps. If you're playing with other people, bass and guitar especially, and they're playing the changes, do you play differently than if you were playing the same song but by yourself?

CL: Yeah. I do. But, because we're following a script. But you know that's interesting I'm just thinking are there any wrong notes, yes there are. The bass player could play — there's mistakes but in looking at your question, depending on these musicians, so you're following the script but if you still start — you start pushing it around all the musicians will follow the improv you know. So it does have — it still has that same freedom, you're taking a little bit more of a risk by pushing outside the boundaries of what you have on the script and hopefully guys will come with you or at least give you the room to do that. Does that make sense?

MR: Yeah. When you turn to the piano to play something unknown, do your hands just — I'm trying to rephrase here — does your mind direct your hands or is it the other way around?

CL: Wow. That's almost like a physics kind of question, because it's so — I don't know it happens so fast, it just happens — you know the response of the notes cause the next thing to happen so quickly man. And that's the beauty of it. You know it isn't magic. I think everybody can do it. You know I teach some kids at this gifted school I teach at once a week and you know they don't have any knowledge of the past of music or whatever. And I'll get them to like, "Okay here just do this with your left hand

[plays]

and now major scale. You know go ahead and

[plays]

there's nothing complex about it but you know that's the beginning of

[musical interlude]

MR: Okay what's the name of that? You have to name it. That was actually a question I use sometimes is where do you get your titles from. Do you think your mood affects the way that you would improvise?

CL: That's a good question. The only way I can think of to answer that is like going to do a concert and I'm nervous. Oh man I don't feel connected, I don't feel grounded, you know and I hope I'm going to be able to play. I do these little things, and right up to the point of the gig. And then, "Ladies and gentlemen" blah-blah and then you go out and it's all gone again. It's all like I knew you'd be there.

MR: Why did you have to wait so long?

CL: Yeah, but you know, so whatever that process is. So as far as the mood I think as soon as I start playing there's some switch that goes off. You know it, you know that feeling.

MR: Was there any hesitation on your part when the opportunity to join the Brubeck Brothers came up?

CL: Was there any?

MR: Hesitation.

CL: No.

MR: Okay. How familiar were you with Dave Brubeck's music?

CL: I was very familiar.

MR: Okay.

CL: He was one of the first guys I heard jazz-wise. The drummer I was referring to back in the early days that my brother John brought down from Columbia was a super audiophile dude and he would turn us on to stuff, you know Pharoah Sanders, McCoy and all this stuff. But I had been playing piano for maybe a year but it was happening pretty quickly for me and I remember I was at the piano doing stuff and Jon Margolis, he's the drummer from Dry Jack, right, he had a reel to reel tape recorder and he came up with these headphones and he put them on, he just put them on me, and it was the "Time Out" record. And I had never heard — I hadn't heard a lot of stuff but that in particular was, "What is this?" The sound of it, the sound of the drums, the vibe of it you know, so I was a Brubeck fan in two seconds.

MR: Same here. Of course I had the Desmond — you know being a saxophone player Paul Desmond like — oh, something about it really grabbed me and you I guess. So what can you tell us about Dave Brubeck that really struck you?

CL: You mean the music?

MR: Dave the man.

CL: Oh the man, oh just — he was one of the most, he was one of the kindest most gentle spirit. He was like a kid in a lot of ways. And you know we'd listen to music. I remember this one day he got out you know like four or five CDs from different people. He was always getting CDs. And we'd listen to it and talk about it and analyze, and he'd be talking about you know when he went to the Pacific, you know in college when he was a young man. And he's going, "I could play like Art Tatum, man, I had that accident. Listen to —" and — you know because his technique was his own thing and it was a lot of rhythm-based stuff which I totally related to. But he put this thing on man and it really, it sounded like Tatum. He was just burning. And then he had that accident with his — broke his back. And you know we've talked about that too where he just said, "Well I had facility but I had to re-learn how to do it and as I was doing that I started developing what this sound was and I got more into rhythm." You know it changed his direction and it made him who he was all through his — you know to have an accident like that, "Ah I'm done. I'm not going to play anymore. I can't play like I used to" or whatever. You know he taught me so much stuff.

MR: Did you ever hear that bit about, this was near the beginning of when his career was taking off and critics were saying he can't swing. And there's a thing in *DownBeat* where he says, "Any jackass can swing." That's probably the nastiest word he ever said.

CL: Yeah, right, I was going to say man. Oh God, man, yeah that was a thrill when you asked if I was apprehensive about joining the quartet, but you know I was really excited about it but within the first minute I'm going, "When can I meet your dad?" You know I was like that's going to happen now, I'm going to get to meet him. So that was really exciting.

MR: And Iola was an angel.

CL: My God. What a powerful, quiet powerful woman. You know? That was a killer couple, man.

MR: A killer couple, yeah, in a really good way. Did you feel, especially in the beginning when you were with them, that you should try to give a nod to Dave in the way you played, especially on iconic tunes you know, if you were playing "Blue Rondo a la Turk" or, I mean there are certain things you need to play.

CL: Right. The melodies and that.

MR: But when it came time to the improvising?

CL: I don't think so. You know I'm thinking back at the beginning I know for sure you know now and for the last fifteen years, but I don't think that was ever present. I don't think I ever felt the need to, you know, I remember at the beginning there'd be some old curmudgeons coming up, "You've got some tough shoes to fill young man." You know that kind of thing. And Dave and I joked about that because I told him that and he said, "Well I'm a 12-1/2, you're 10-1/2 you know, yeah you do, you've got some big shoes — but I never not even close to be intimidated by the chair. I never even thought about it. Because I played the way I played and I know the dude, that's what Brubeck — wouldn't want it any other way. You know I'm influenced by him naturally but yeah that's an interesting, and I'm really grateful for it, that I never felt like oh I'm in a concert and everybody wants to hear Dave-style. It's like I couldn't do it for one.

MR: I think it's interesting that the brothers — I don't know whose decision this was, but their fourth player is not a saxophone player. Because I think that would have made even this question of trying to sound like Brubeck, even more pressing because then it looks like a real, like we're trying to re-create —

CL: Right. I think so too. I don't know, I know Mike Demicco has been playing with those guys, like he was in a band with Dan Brubeck for — he's been part of the Brubeck thing for 35 years, right? So it was just an organic flow into keeping him. But he has told me, he gets intimidated by — he says, "Yeah man, I know people want to hear saxophone on 'Take Five.' They don't want to hear the guitar." "Don't think about it." Because that sound, even you know we've had sax players we've played with and do you know Lucas Pino?

MR: I do not.

CL: That young guy is hot on the scene. Beautiful player. But when Mike can't be on a gig or something then Lucas or somebody else will. And it really is neat to hear it, you know, I have to admit. How can you not love that sound, the sax with the Brubeck thing.

MR: It's also interesting to hear different versions of the classic Brubeck "Take Five."

CL: Yeah.

MR: You know like sometimes if it's a live version it's a lot faster and it's almost like, "No, that's not how it goes. Didn't you listen to the record?"

CL: Right. Or "Take Five" in four.

MR: That sounds like a good idea.

CL: Yeah I hear ya. Work on it.

MR: You guys tour a lot and it seems like a successful venture. It was a real drag that the Brubeck Centennial got waylaid by the Covid thing.

CL: Yeah. Yeah we had some very substantial concerts that got — you know the Royal Albert Hall and you know things like that. But when we did start playing again that first year, I guess it was summer of 2021, is that possible? But it was all the make-up gigs for the Centennial so we were on the road constantly. But it's a blast I love it. I love the band. And the band is evolving too. You know it's not just stuck in some certain vibe and you play. The improv thing and where we go in that, and you know the trio playing is, you know, it's really developing, which is really neat you know what I mean? Because you can be okay here we go, we're going to do this again. But now it's pushing stuff around musically, rhythm, listening to each other more and it's very cool.

MR: Dan is quite an amazing guy. I remember here we are sitting on the stage that you all played on and I remember listening, at a couple of moments during that concert — I can't remember if it was during a solo or what but I got this notion like I think Dan lost the beat. And boy was I wrong.

CL: Well you know, I know what you mean. Yeah I've been playing with that cat for 20 years now and, you know, his "Take Five" solo, I mean his playing in general but his "Take Five" solo or his solos are just — I'm going man I've heard him do this now I don't know how many thousands of times and I just shake my head standing there on the side of the stage. This dude is unreal. Nobody plays like that you know. I mean it's almost like a rock — Ginger Baker hard hitting thing with like this mastery of time. You know you see this crazy dichotomy of stuff. He is pretty extraordinary.

MR: One part of doing what you do I believe is juggling commitments. Do you have — you have the Caffe Lena thing going and some lessons. Who takes precedence in your — is it the Brubecks that — they get on the calendar first?

CL: Yeah. Yeah. But you know we get the itinerary for the year, are there any conflicts for you guys, because I also do this music with my wife Ria Curley, which is really exciting.

So that and the Caffe Lena gig are my other investments in and love playing. But you know so on the itinerary I just say no I can't do — or it won't be formalized, they'll say does anybody have any conflicts, and they just book around it.

MR: Who books around it? The Brubecks?

CL: Yeah. We have management. They have management, Arc Management they're called.

MR: Okay well that's interesting because that happens on every level of gig playing you know, you get a gig then you call the band or you find a band.

CL: Right, "I hope I can get the right guys" and if you can't —

MR: It makes me think we had an earlier talk about acting professional and all that, because most musicians have lists of instrument players and when they look at it the most skilled person on a particular instrument may not be your first call because of this person might have baggage and you'd rather go with the person who you're going to be happy being around.

CL: That might not be —

MR: Maybe not quite as —

CL: No, I still run into that stuff for sure with the Caffe Lena. So it's a monthly series and I get a different guest every month. And you know you don't mess around on this gig it's not like you show up and hey what do you want to play. This was like you learn this cat's stuff really well, you know his recordings, you listen to it, you come in. And I've had guys show up, "Oh man, oh here's the charts" and didn't rehearse, and that guy is like I'd rather get a younger guy or whatever, that he'll devote his time. So yeah I know what you mean and I agree and I do run into that still.

MR: Are you paying attention out there all you young aspiring —

CL: Yeah well.

MR: This question usually does not work, but do you recall any train wreck type gigs?

CL: You mean just in —

MR: Just in general, a gig that was terrible?

CL: Not really man. Not really. You know there's been some train wrecks on stage on a tune where it derails and sort of like what we were talking about before, the bass player gets lost and you know you've got 150 people there. And they probably don't notice, you know, as you know that reality in the live gig thing. But you know it usually — I don't know for some reason I'm just thinking of when we do these orchestra gigs with the Brubecks, you know playing with the full orchestra there'll be like rehearsal the day — dress rehearsal the day of the concert and this stuff is like there's parts that are just they can't keep the time like if it's triplets, the triplet figure, they can't play them. They play triplets differently. They phrase them different. It's a train wreck and we're like crashing and burning. And it's like okay. And we get to the gig and do it and it's always been cool.

But those are pre-gig things but you know those are ones where I think oh man this ain't going to happen.

MR: Orchestra ain't swinging.

CL: Orchestra ain't swinging. It's an interesting thing man because to classical people what a triplet is, you know, how you swing, how do you swing a triplet, you know the typical eighth note swing but the triplet one is always the one that's —

MR: And does Chris write those orchestra charts?

CL: He does some of them, a lot of those are Dave's and if they're not Dave's some of them are Dave's brother Henry. Is it Henry?

MR: Howard?

CL: Howard. Thank you.

MR: I recall when I interviewed him I was enamored at the time — well when he first came up with his first orchestral piece, I think it was called "Elementals." And he didn't know what he was doing. He pretty much told me, he said, "I didn't know how to score, I didn't know ranges really well." And I could almost picture some of the orchestral people going, "I can't read this, who did this?"

CL: Sure man, God. You know now so that's my goal is I've been wanting to do it for a long time is to write orchestral music and woodwind quintets and things. So I just started studying that, it's my New Year's resolution this year and I'm going to write something for maybe woodwind quintet or string quartet. Probably not orchestra but that's my ultimate goal. I've got so many ideas for that and Chris Brubeck is a really great orchestral writer and has been really supportive in that. So I'm really excited to get that happening. You know that's my dream.

MR: Yeah. You can learn a lot when someone finally goes to play it, just like observing and watching the players, like do they grimace or like okay how come they made a face at that thing. What is it about that, I'll try not to do that.

CL: That's a good one. You know. Have you done that? Have you done orchestral?

MR: Yeah I've done some orchestral pieces and quintets and that kind of thing. It's tricky with Finale or whatever if you use that stuff too because you can put anything you want into Finale and it will play it back perfectly. But then you give it to a live person it could be a different story.

CL: Right. The learning curve is going to be —

MR: Let me ask you about a couple of people that, according to your own resume, you have crossed paths with. Bela Fleck?

CL: Forget about it. Amazing. You know that dude, we were playing, well I was doing this, my first experience playing with him was at it was called E-town which is a radio show, it's like the "Prairie Home Companion" and it's in Boulder. And so E-town had the

Flecktones and I was playing with different people. But before we had finished all the rehearsals and stuff and the stage was dark and I went over and started playing a little bit and Bela came over with his banjo and Victor Wooten came over. So we just sat there and just improvised together for about an hour. It was like — this dude — and his quest for knowledge. You know like if I was playing

[musical interlude]

something like — he'd go what? What was that? What was that phrase? You know. Whatever. He'd want to know right away and then I'd show him. And he'd go [scats] he'd go this is nice. [scats] Right? He'd start doing — but that really struck me aside from just being blown away just quietly improvising with those guys and stuff.

MR: When you answered him what is that, you didn't say this is a downward Lydian symmetric diminished —

CL: Well I mean I don't remember exactly what it was but it was something that we were vamping on a D minor 9 or whatever. So I had done something up above, I said well a half-step approach thing, so there was an answer to it. I said I think it was kind of this sort of motion based on it.

MR: Did you hear the Flecktones Christmas CD? You should, just the "Twelve Days of Christmas" is worth.

CL: Oh man, I will.

MR: Sit down when you listen to it. What about Ginger Baker?

CL: Ginger Baker man, holy cow. So that was my gig in Vail that I told you about, the club called Louie's that I had for eight, nine years. And I was bringing all these different people in and somebody had told me, I think the club owner, this young dude, he said, "Do you know that Ginger Baker moved to Denver?" I go, "You're kidding." And he had a horse ranch or a horse farm, or whatever. And I said, "Oh cool I'll call him and see if I can get him." And I called a friend who had done some work on the farm, I call up and he answers the phone. And I said, "Hey Ginger, how you doing man, this is Chuck Lamb I'm a pianist and I'd doing a gig in Vail, I'd like you to come up and play, it's a jazz gig." And he goes, "How much does it pay?" And he came up. That was a trip. Because — so the club is pretty small, it was sort of like Caffe Lena, probably 90 seats, smaller stage. And I show up I said you know, "Ginger I'll meet you in the alley way to bring your stuff in." So I go to the alley way and come around the corner, the alley way is full of drum cases that say "Cream" on 'em. And I go in, the whole stage is filled with, you know two bass drums, toms, two floor tom toms, the whole — and he's sitting there and he's smoking a cigarette you know — there's no room — I set the keyboard on the floor and it was like that. I loved it though, I loved coming around the corner and seeing those cases.

MR: How did he play?

CL: Well he was, you know, he was kind of clunky but you could tell he had played jazz and it had been a long time and he wanted to get back into it but — I'm just thinking of the one we were doing, like we were doing

[musical interlude]

Right?

MR: Yeah. "Alone Together."

CL: What is that, "Yesterdays" or "Alone Together."

MR: "Alone Together." Yeah.

CL: So we were doing that and they were swinging and my solo

[quotes "Sunshine of Your Love"]

and then I started going like

[musical interlude]

Right? Started doing this thing on it, and he, it's like he forgot where he was and he went into [scats] and the crowd went nuts and he looked at me, and you know he was pissed because that's not what he was doing anymore but the funny part was, I mean I wasn't doing it to bust his chops obviously, I was doing it to honor him, but you know he wanted to be known as a jazz drummer and he was really upset. But he lost it, you know, you could see him go back to it and he went right into [scats]. I always enjoyed that.

MR: "Just when I got out you pulled me back in." That's funny. Wow.

CL: Ginger Baker.

MR: How about Ernie Watts?

CL: Do you know Ernie?

MR: Yeah I interviewed him years ago.

CL: Do you know how he is? Have you had any contact with him? Because I haven't for years. He lived over near Aspen, he lived in Carbondale, so he was another guy I could reach out to and grab and pull in. He was, what an incredible musician that dude is. What a vocabulary he had and just a sweetheart of a guy you know, just embracing of everybody. Great charts.

MR: He said something interesting, that he learned — the first music he learned was very difficult music — like "Giant Steps" and he didn't know it was hard. So anything that came after that, like all that studio work he did and laying in solos on all those records was — I'm not sure what adjective he used but he had learned on the hardest stuff there was.

CL: That's great. What a neat thing man, because everything is easier after that, you know if you tackle that out of the gate.

MR: Well you could almost say the same thing, you heard Chick Corea and Return to Forever when you were just in your yout'.

CL: Yeah right, the yout'.

MR: Any other characters that have stuck out in your — I see something about Woody Herman. Well Dave Holland you mentioned. Peter Frampton, why would you cross paths with Peter Frampton?

CL: He was — there was a rock concert in — I was trying to review that history, I asked Rod Fleeman about that when Dry Jack was living in Kansas City and there was a rock, multi-band rock show. And we were — Dry Jack was one of the — for some reason I guess 'cause we were local, but this was a heavy duty — I can remember the other — I think maybe Ray Charles was even in it. But there was a jam session and I was invited out, Rod and I were invited out to play with him. So that was the — looks good on the resume.

MR: Yeah. If you got a commission to write a new original piece how would you start? Now let's suppose it's a pretty open-ended thing. It could be a solo piano composition or maybe it could turn into a group thing from there. But is there a way you approach the piano differently if you know I need to write something, I need to write something that is playable by me but other people also, as opposed to just like what you did a couple of times today already, just your hands start going.

CL: What would I?

MR: Is there a method that you might use to get an initial idea?

CL: You know it depends on, that's a pretty open question but you know I think I'd probably start with some sort of you know bass, like if I was asked to compose you know something like that I might like start with

[musical interlude]

MR: Lovely.

CL: So maybe something thematic like that and then a simpler melody like if I'm thinking of somebody playing it or doubling it you know like that.

[musical interlude]

answer — I'd be thinking in simpler concepts like that, like something that somebody could really grab on to and would sound moody and lush kind of built into it right away. That's a thought.

MR: Thank you. I loved the second chord you played, it was like I'm not on camera but it made me go like that. It was a nice change.

CL: A nice surprise. Thank you.

MR: Just to wrap up, the state of music technology and the market and that whole scene. Do you have any observations on it?

CL: Just in general?

MR: How does it — does it affect your livelihood? The fact that well for instance I can watch you and the other people from Small's, right? A live stream.

CL: Yeah incredible.

MR: I don't have to pay for it.

CL: That's a great point. That part is amazing. As we know it that developed full force from the Covid thing you know, the live stream reality. And like the Caffe Lena gig I get people from all over the world tuning in to watch these, so that part of technology is incredible and also just the recording, the whole recording stuff that you can like we're working on Ria's new EP, you know and, Ria and I got married on 10/10/21. Or I don't know if you knew that?

MR: I did not know that.

CL: Yeah so I just want to get that on the thing because I love her and it's incredible to meet somebody you know later on in your life that is your partner and that it's really cool to be with somebody and you love their music, and the stuff she writes. So we have a blast playing you know her playing piano and singing her tunes and I play acoustic piano and improvise behind it, and then a rhythm section. That's a really neat vibe. But to be able to put ideas down at home on a recorder and play them back and they sound incredible so to me the home rig, you know, to be able to do that, like that little thing I just played, what if I really dug that I could really put it down and make a beautiful recording, and then I could master it all at home. I mean you know you want to take it up to the studio technology is incredible also. Ultimately you take it there. But I love that stuff man. I think that's, and as far as a learning tool for kids, for players developing, it's ridiculous you know that they can access any solo, any recorded solo, Charlie Parker whatever, slow it down you know, it's instantaneous that's why — one of the reasons why I think there are so many incredible young players out there, the guys that do it right. It can make you lazy too, make the young players miss some steps. They want to get to — but anyway.

MR: What will you do product-wise when you finish the recording with Ria?

CL: Well we're doing — she's going to do an EP and then it'll be downloadable, but we're going to make CDs also even though I don't know where that's at these days.

MR: I know but you almost, it just feels like you should.

CL: You know what I mean? You know? I want the thing. I love this you know, oh man this was great, but at least a CD and oh man, it's just something you can pick up. And sell a lot of them on gigs you know so that's like, so we're doing a CD release party on May 19th at Caffe Lena for her. And you know she's doing it in a more music-industry way. She's going to release singles. That's the thing you do. You do a promo thing, you do push, you release a single this month and next month and that's a whole different world for me. Usually it's like this record I did with Harvey Sorgen and Jay Anderson, you know you go in you play, you record it and you put it out on BandCamp and then off to the next. You know all that. I'm sure you've been down those avenues.

MR: Well, Chuck, this has been a long time coming.

CL: It has, Monk, thank you, thanks for doing this.

MR: And I admire your talent and congratulations on your career and whatever comes next.

CL: Thank you man, appreciate it.

MR: Do you want to play us out?

CL: Sure.

[musical interlude]

Yeah, man.

MR: Bravisse

CL: Yeah. Thanks bro.

MR: Thank you.